

Some sectors continue to recruit during final placements, while others such as FMCG companies, parts of BFSI, and niche finance firms often prefer to see student interns in action before a hiring call"

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Companies are hiring where they have a clear business need and concentrating on institutions and talent pools where they see stronger alignment with those needs"

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recruiters are coming, but they are not necessarily hiring more.

MORE IS LESS

S. Pasupathi, Chief Operating Officer at HirePro, an AI-powered recruitment and talent acquisition platform, says the number of companies visiting campuses has risen by an indicative 8–10%, but the number of offers is not increasing.

As companies get more selective in signing up candidates, it is also pushing up pay for those seen as particularly valuable. MDI Gurgaon says companies were willing to pay a premium for students they were keen to hire.

To be sure, PPO numbers alone are an imperfect measure of recruiter appetite. A decline in PPOs does not necessarily mean weaker recruiter appetite. If companies are increasing internship hiring while becoming more selective about conversion, the final PPO number may reflect a tighter funnel rather than weaker demand.

Han Digital Group's data adds another layer to the picture. Its analysis shows the recruiter base across B-schools has increased by up to 15% from last year, with some premium institutions seeing their recruiter base nearly double. Yet greater recruiter participation is not translating uniformly into either higher placements or compensation.

According to Pasupathi, average salaries at premier institutes are in the ₹22–28 lakh range, compared with roughly ₹4–8 lakh at lower-tier colleges. Internship stipends can differ by two to three times.

Placement rates at Tier-I and Tier-II B-schools remain in the 85–95% range, according to Han Digital, but average packages at Tier-II institutes are down by roughly 10–15%. The difference is increasingly about the kind of roles being recruited for.

At Tier I institutes, consulting and strategy continue to dominate, with consulting accounting for roughly 40–45% of placements at IIMs, while BFSI and fintech typically account for another 20–30%. At Tier II schools, the mix is broader, with sales and marketing, analytics, HR operations, supply chain, finance and technology consulting emerging as important hiring functions.

Recruiters are also widening their sourcing pools. Tier II institutes are increasingly being tapped for functional roles as companies look beyond traditional Tier I campuses, driven not only by cost but also by retention and cultural fit.

THE PREMIUM FOR BEING AT THE TOP

The *BT*-MDRA survey shows just how sharply the salary gap between the best B-schools and the rest has widened. Average domestic salaries at the Top 10 schools have nearly doubled since 2015, reaching ₹29.9 lakh this year. Across the Top 100, however, the average rose 67% to ₹13.26 lakh.

The divergence becomes starker lower down the rankings: while salaries at the Top 10 have risen strongly over the past decade, growth has been much slower among schools in the lower-ranked bands, with the 76–100 group seeing a decline of 5.6% to ₹7.26 lakh this year.

Government schools, including the IIMs, commanded higher salaries, with the average at ₹20.3 lakh in 2026, compared to ₹11.5 lakh for private colleges.

The variation is also visible within individual campuses and for internships. At K J Somaiya, for instance, the 2024–26 final placements attracted a highest package at ₹29.3 lakh, with the median at ₹12 lakh. In the 2025–27 summer internship cycle at the same